without a murmur. Concluding his remarks at the Presidium meeting, Khrushchev expressed confidence that "the pragmatic Americans would not venture on a senseless risk, just as we cannot now undertake anything against the American missiles aimed at the Soviet Union in Turkey, Italy, and the FRG." He added: "After all, sensible politicians in the USA should think just as we are thinking today." The cool-headed politicians Khrushchev had in mind were President Kennedy and his supporters in the Democratic Party. He did not want the Soviet missile deployment to hurt their chances in the November 1962 congressional elections, which gave him a further reason to insist on the secrecy of the operation. "It is especially important to avoid publicity at a time when political passions are reaching their peak in the USA—the Congressional election campaign," he said.[15]

Khrushchev's speech served as a formulation of the position to be taken by the senior delegation, headed by the Uzbek communist party secretary Sharof Rashidov, that was scheduled to depart for Cuba in a few days. At the top of its official agenda was economic, not military, assistance to Cuba. The nuclear missiles were the responsibility of Marshal Biriuzov, who was to join the group, as was the ambassador-designate Alekseev. Before the delegates departed, Khrushchev hosted them at a state country house near Moscow. Alekseev remembered that among the members of the Central Committee Presidium there was an atmosphere of relaxation and "complete unanimity." The leader who had effectively silenced the opposition gave a farewell speech. Off they went.[16]

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ON MAY 28 RASHIDOV, BIRIUZOV, AND ALEKSEEV, ALONG with the rest of the delegation, left for Guinea, a West African nation that had gained independence from France in 1962 and was now allied with the Soviets. From there they departed for Havana: as there were no direct flights between the Soviet Union and Cuba, Conakry, the capital of Guinea, would become a stopover for dozens if not hundreds of Soviet military officers on their way to the "island of freedom." The day after leaving Moscow,